



SMARTIE

Synergistic Management and Advancement of Artificial
Intelligence in European Higher Education

WP2 – Alliance for Artificial Intelligence in Higher Education – Setup SMARTIE

T2.1 Setup of Alliance for AI - SMARTIE

D.2.1.1. Alliance for Artificial Intelligence in Higher Education - SMARTIE

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1. Foreword

The accelerated development of artificial intelligence is transforming higher education at pedagogical, organizational, managerial, and strategic levels. Universities are increasingly required to adapt curricula, teaching methods, digital infrastructure, research priorities, and stakeholder cooperation models in order to respond effectively to the opportunities and challenges created by AI. In this context, the creation of coordinated alliances dedicated to the responsible and meaningful integration of AI in higher education is both timely and necessary.

SMARTIE is conceived as such an alliance: a collaborative framework bringing together higher education institutions and relevant stakeholders with the common purpose of promoting the integration of artificial intelligence in higher education systems, teaching and learning processes, institutional development, and university–society cooperation. The alliance is intended to serve as a platform for strategic coordination, knowledge exchange, capacity building, policy dialogue, and joint action.

This document establishes the framework of SMARTIE, defines its internal governance structure, clarifies the rules of cooperation among its members, identifies the categories of entities that may join the alliance, and outlines the roles and responsibilities of its main bodies. It also describes the main objectives of SMARTIE and the national and European resources that may be mobilized in support of these objectives.

2. Introduction

The integration of artificial intelligence in higher education is not limited to the adoption of digital tools. It requires a coherent ecosystem involving universities, researchers, teachers, students, policymakers, employers, professional bodies, technology providers, and civil society actors. Such integration must be based on shared principles, clear governance arrangements, responsible innovation, and long-term cooperation.

SMARTIE – the Alliance of Artificial Intelligence – is established as a cooperative framework intended to support higher education institutions in the design, implementation, assessment, and continuous improvement of AI-related educational, organizational, and strategic practices. The alliance promotes collaboration across institutional and national boundaries, encourages the exchange of good practices, and supports joint initiatives aimed at increasing AI readiness in higher education.

This framework document serves as the foundational reference for the functioning of SMARTIE. It sets out the structure of the alliance, the composition and responsibilities of its governing entities, the criteria for membership, the expected conduct of members, and the types of resources that may be engaged in order to achieve its objectives.

3. Alliance for AI in HE

3.1 Name

The official name of the alliance is:

SMARTIE – Alliance of Artificial Intelligence for the Integration of AI in Higher Education

3.2 What is SMARTIE?

SMARTIE is a collaborative, multi-stakeholder (academia, economic agents, public services, authorities, policy makers, non-governmental organisations, etc.), non-exclusive alliance based on voluntary cooperation among its members. It functions as a strategic and operational framework for joint activities, mutual learning, coordinated initiatives, and policy support related to the integration of AI in higher education.

3.3 SMARTIE objectives

The main objective of SMARTIE is to support and accelerate the meaningful, responsible, inclusive, and sustainable integration of artificial intelligence in higher education. The specific objectives are:

- Curriculum and Teaching Innovation: to support the modernization of curricula, disciplines, teaching methods, and learning environments through the integration of AI-related tools, concepts, and pedagogical approaches.
- Capacity Building: to strengthen the competences of academic staff, administrative staff, students, and institutional leaders regarding the effective and ethical use of AI in higher education.
- Research and Knowledge Exchange: to promote cooperation in research, experimentation, dissemination of good practices, and exchange of expertise related to AI adoption in higher education.
- Institutional Development: to support universities in developing strategies, governance models, quality assurance mechanisms, and internal policies related to the use of AI.
- Ethical and Responsible AI Use: to encourage the use of AI in a way that respects academic integrity, transparency, data protection, inclusion, human oversight, and ethical principles.
- Labour Market Relevance: to strengthen the alignment between higher education outcomes and labour market needs by promoting AI-related competences that improve graduate employability and adaptability.

- Stakeholder Cooperation: to foster structured cooperation between universities and external stakeholders, including employers, public institutions, NGOs, professional associations, and technology actors.
- Policy Support and Sustainability: to contribute to national and European discussions, strategies, and policy initiatives concerning AI in education and to ensure the long-term sustainability of alliance actions.

3.4 SMARTIE organizational structure, roles and responsibilities

SMARTIE alliance of Artificial Intelligence for the Integration of AI in Higher Education will operate through the following governance and participation structure presented in Figure 1.

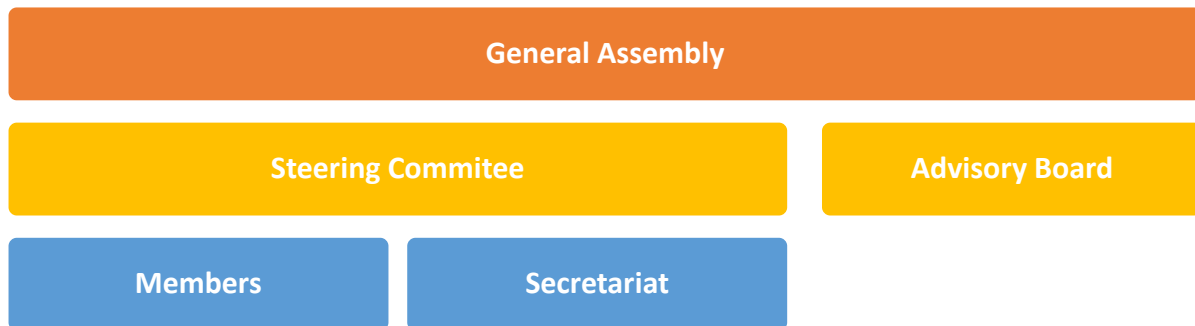


Figure 1 Structure of SMARTIE

SMARTIE General Assembly

Role of General Assembly

The General Assembly is the broad representative body of SMARTIE, composed of all alliance members. It serves as the main forum for consultation, validation of strategic directions, review of progress, and collective discussion of priorities. The General Assembly includes one or more authorized representatives from each member institution or organization.

Responsibilities of General Assembly:

- approve the overall strategic directions of the alliance
- review annual activity plans and progress reports
- discuss major priorities, challenges, and opportunities for SMARTIE
- endorse recommendations proposed by the Steering Committee
- support the visibility and sustainability of the alliance
- facilitate exchange of experiences among members

SMARTIE Steering Committee

Role of Steering Committee

The Steering Committee is the main strategic and executive governance body of SMARTIE. It ensures the coordination, coherence, and implementation of the alliance's objectives and activities. The Steering Committee shall be composed of representatives designated by key member institutions, ideally ensuring balance in terms of geography, institutional profile, and expertise. The coordinating institution may chair the Steering Committee unless otherwise agreed by the members. The Steering Committee shall meet regularly, in physical or online format, according to an agreed calendar. Extraordinary meetings may be convened when needed. Decisions should preferably be taken by consensus; where consensus is not possible, a qualified majority rule may be applied as defined in internal procedures.

Responsibilities of Steering Committee:

- define the strategic priorities and operational orientation of SMARTIE;
- approve annual or multiannual work plans;
- monitor implementation of agreed actions and deliverables;
- oversee internal coordination among alliance bodies;
- support the preparation of strategic documents, action plans, and cooperation initiatives;
- decide on membership applications, suspension, or termination, according to alliance rules;
- ensure compliance with the mission, values, and objectives of SMARTIE;
- establish thematic working groups where needed;
- validate proposals for external partnerships, dissemination activities, and sustainability actions;
- monitor risks, resource mobilization, and quality of cooperation.

Advisory Board

Role of Advisory Board

The Advisory Board is a consultative body that provides independent expertise, strategic guidance, external perspective, and recommendations to strengthen the quality and relevance of SMARTIE activities. The Advisory Board will include experts from higher education, AI and digital innovation, educational policy, ethics and legal compliance, labour market organizations, industry and technology sectors, quality assurance and accreditation bodies, civil society and public administration. The Advisory Board has a consultative, not executive, role. Its recommendations are not binding, but they should be considered seriously by the Steering Committee and members. Each country member will have 1 representative in Advisory Board. The mandate of members of Advisory Board will last 3 years.

Responsibilities of Advisory Board:

- provide expert advice on strategic, pedagogical, ethical, and technical issues;
- review progress and offer recommendations for improvement;
- support the alignment of SMARTIE with European and national developments;
- contribute to the quality, relevance, and innovation potential of alliance outputs;
- advise on sustainability, transferability, and stakeholder engagement;
- identify emerging trends and opportunities relevant to AI in higher education.

SMARTIE Members

Role of members

Members form the operational and collaborative basis of the alliance. They participate in activities, contribute expertise and resources, and implement or support actions consistent with SMARTIE objectives.

Responsibilities of members:

- support the mission and objectives of SMARTIE;
- participate actively in alliance meetings, consultations, and initiatives;
- designate contact persons or representatives for communication and coordination;
- contribute knowledge, practices, tools, case studies, or resources relevant to AI integration in higher education;
- disseminate alliance activities and results within their networks;
- respect the governance rules, ethical principles, and cooperation standards of SMARTIE;
- contribute, where possible, to the sustainability and visibility of the alliance;
- participate in joint actions, pilot activities, research, training, or dissemination events when relevant.

Secretariat

Role of secretariat

The secretariat has administrative role and communication support.

Responsibilities of secretariat:

- organize meetings;
- maintain records and communication;
- support reporting and coordination;
- facilitate implementation logistics

4. Membership in the SMARTIE alliance

4.1 Who can join SMARTIE?

SMARTIE is open to institutions and organizations that share its mission and are willing to contribute to the integration of AI in higher education. Eligible members may include:

- universities and other higher education institutions;
- research institutes and academic networks;
- vocational and professional training providers connected to higher education pathways;
- public authorities and public agencies relevant to education, innovation, or digital policy;
- professional associations;
- NGOs and civil society organizations active in education, digital transformation, or inclusion;
- technology companies and digital solution providers;
- quality assurance, accreditation, or policy-support organizations;
- student associations or representative bodies;
- other organizations whose activities are relevant to the mission of SMARTIE.

To join the alliance, an applicant should agree the following principles and procedures for admission:

- demonstrate relevance to the objectives of SMARTIE;
- commit to the values and cooperation principles of the alliance;
- express willingness to participate actively in alliance activities;
- designate a representative and a contact point;
- accept this framework and any associated internal cooperation rules.

The pathway for joining SMARTIE alliance means to respect the admission procedure presented in Figure 2.



Figure 2 Admission Procedure

The members have the following rights: participate in the General Assembly; contribute to discussions, initiatives, and working groups; access shared information and outputs of the

alliance; propose activities, partnerships, and thematic priorities; benefit from cooperation, visibility, and knowledge exchange within the alliance.

4.2 Internal cooperation

Cooperation

Cooperation within SMARTIE shall be based on the following principles: mutual respect; trust and transparency; shared responsibility; inclusiveness and non-discrimination; academic freedom and institutional autonomy; responsible and ethical use of AI; openness to innovation and interdisciplinarity; commitment to quality and sustainability.

Communication

Members shall maintain regular and clear communication through agreed channels. Important decisions, meeting outcomes, and action points should be documented and shared appropriately.

Participation

Members are expected to participate actively in meetings, consultations, joint actions, and dissemination activities, according to their role and capacity.

Decision-Making

Strategic decisions shall normally be taken by the Steering Committee and validated, where appropriate, by the General Assembly. Consensus should be the preferred approach. Internal procedures may define voting thresholds for specific matters.

Information sharing

Members are encouraged to share relevant resources, expertise, case studies, training opportunities, policy developments, and project initiatives that can contribute to alliance objectives.

Ethics

All alliance activities shall respect applicable ethical principles, data protection requirements, academic integrity standards, inclusion objectives, and legal rules relevant to AI use and educational cooperation.

Visibility and use of SMARTIE results and outputs

Alliance outputs, where jointly developed, should acknowledge the contribution of SMARTIE and its members according to agreed dissemination and branding rules.

Conflicts mitigation

In the event of disagreement, members should first seek resolution through dialogue and mediation within the alliance governance structure. Where necessary, the Steering Committee may issue recommendations or take formal decisions.

5. Engaged Resources

To achieve its objectives, SMARTIE may engage a broad range of national and European resources.

National Level

- university infrastructure and institutional expertise;
- national education and research funding schemes;
- ministries responsible for education, digitalization, research, labour, and innovation;
- national agencies for quality assurance, digital development, or project funding;
- public-private partnerships;
- national AI strategies and digital education strategies;
- regional innovation ecosystems;
- employer associations and sectoral councils;
- national centres for teacher training and lifelong learning;
- local and regional authorities supporting education and digital transformation.

European Level

- Erasmus+ programme opportunities;
- Horizon Europe research and innovation funding;
- Digital Europe Programme;
- European Universities initiatives;
- European Institute of Innovation and Technology communities where relevant;
- European policy frameworks on AI, digital education, and skills;
- European networks and associations of higher education institutions;
- European Social Fund Plus and cohesion-related opportunities where applicable;
- EU-level platforms for digital skills, micro-credentials, and lifelong learning;
- guidance and policy resources developed by the European Commission and relevant European agencies.

Additional Resources

- open educational resources;
- open-source AI tools where appropriate;
- joint research outputs and case studies;
- expert volunteering and knowledge contributions;
- collaborative dissemination channels and stakeholder networks.

6. Conclusion

SMARTIE is established as a strategic alliance dedicated to supporting the integration of artificial intelligence in higher education through cooperation, shared expertise, and coordinated action. Its effectiveness depends on a clear governance model, active participation of members, responsible and transparent cooperation, and the ability to mobilize national and European resources in support of common goals.

By defining its structure, membership rules, objectives, governance bodies, and roles and responsibilities, this framework creates the conditions for SMARTIE to function as a credible and sustainable platform for innovation in higher education. Through the collaboration of universities and relevant stakeholders, the alliance can contribute significantly to the modernization of higher education systems and to the preparation of learners, teachers, and institutions for an AI-driven future.